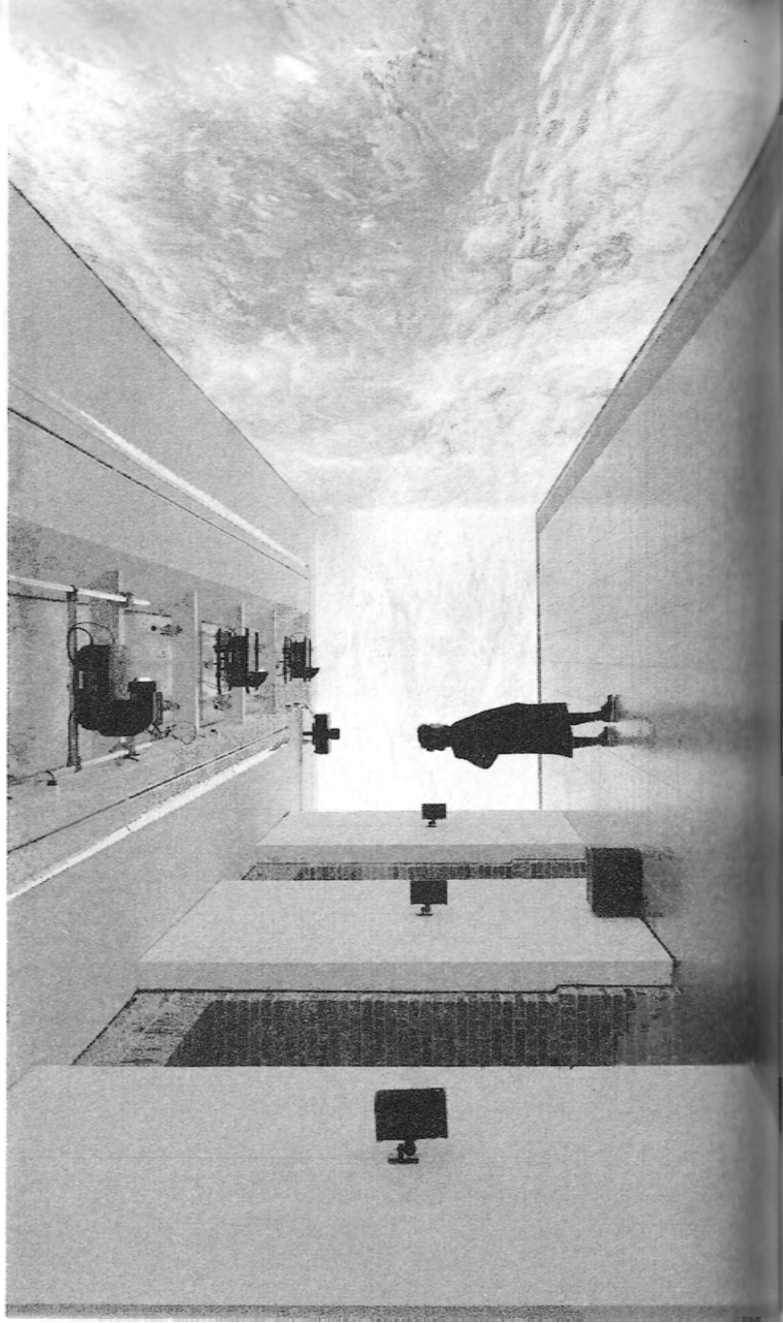


06 – GLITCH ENCRYPTS



The whole concept of visibility assumes that you're not in a system that wants you dead. I think a lot of people forget that many of the places we are inserted in want to kill us . . .

We're not supposed to be there.

—Sondra Perry¹

Gender is, to call on a term coined by philosopher Timothy Morton, a “hyperobject.”² It is all-encompassing, it out-scales us. As such, it becomes difficult to see the edges of gender when submerged within its logic, thereby bolstering the fantasy of its permanence through its apparent omnipresence. In short, gender is *so big*, it becomes invisible.

This is where the problem lies: in the invisibility that becomes seemingly organic. This “normative ordinary” is a violence, suggesting a natural order in lieu of a most unnatural system of control. In asserting itself as part of a vast normative ordinary, gender embeds itself within what we see and experience in the everyday, winding itself through the public networks and spaces that we live in.

As a hyperobject, gender becomes a geopolitical territory. It is a foundational framework, built and lived on.

Unable to see its edges, we are forced to live within it as a world in and of itself. This is why, in order to reimagine the body, one must reimagine space. Revolutionary change manifests through a reconsideration of the spatial, in negotiation of spatial limitations and identification of how to overturn, dissolve, break through these boundaries. Therefore, deterritorialization of the body requires a departure from the heaviness of space, with the realization, instead, that physical form is dynamic.

Philosopher and sociologist Henri Lefebvre writes, "The body serves both as point of departure, and as destination."³ The body, thus, is an inspiration, a springboard, a conceptual catalyst, carrying us away from it as we travel through it. Immersed within the hyperobject of gender, it becomes important to figure out ways to signify its edges and folds, those cuts and stitches that point to the failures of what is assumed to be the natural world around us, aiding our departure from it.

Encryption is useful here as we search for those departure destinations, those moments where peeling back the layers of our presumptions reveals things hidden just below the surface. Encryption, as a process, indicates the encoding of a message, rendering it unreadable or inaccessible to those unauthorized to decipher it. To consider glitch as a form of encryption, we render the *plaintext* of the body (e.g., the body viewed through a normative,

binary lens) as *ciphertext* (e.g., a glitched body, queered and encrypted). Encryption offers a mode of privacy; encoding of content creates secure passageways for radical production. Glitches as encrypted (machinic, social, cultural) material remind "us that there are gaps and hidden histories, parts of the . . . file that . . . cannot [be] heard and stories . . . [that] will never [be] know[n]" to certain audiences.⁴ Through this encryption, the glitch creates a new vernacular, one that allows for new modes of signification and is smuggled through the hyperobject of our hyper-gendered daily lives.

The (de)coding of gender becomes as much about how it is constructed as whether it can or cannot be read. Readability of bodies only according to standard social and cultural coding (e.g., to be white, to be cisgender, to be straight) renders glitched bodies invisible, extends safety, keeps bodies un-surveilled. Glitched bodies pose a very real threat to social order: encrypted and unreadable within a strictly gendered worldview, they resist normative programming. Illegible to the mainstream, the encrypted glitch seizes upon the creation of a self that, depending on the audience, can at once be hypervisible and simultaneously unreadable, undetectable.

This experience of being hypervisible and invisible all at once can be vulnerable. Artist Glenn Ligon's work "Untitled (I Feel Most Colored When I am Thrown

Against a Sharp White Background)" (1990) speaks to this blurriness, and its vulnerability. A text-based work that prints and reprints the words of its title in black block lettering against a white background, Ligon's words take different form as they progress, as they bleed between letters, becoming increasingly difficult to decipher.⁵ It is a meditation on the limits of language. This work, these words, as they deteriorate, illustrate in their very form the violence that comes with the strict delineation of selfhood, of the body, when processed in contrast with another. Ligon's work highlights the problem of space and territory; distinguishing that which *is* via that which *is not* is a binary process of categorization that strips away humanity, leaving us all bare.

Artist Sondra Perry's exhibition *Typhoon coming on*, debuted as a site-specific installation at London's Serpentine Gallery in 2018, immersed the viewer in a surround projection of waves, the water and title in reference to British artist J. M. W. Turner's painting "Slave Ship (Slavers Throwing Overboard the Dead and Dying, Typhoon Coming On)" (1840). Turner's painting was inspired by the massacre of 130 African slaves by the British crew of the slave ship *Zong* in 1781. Using Blender, an open-source 3D graphics program, Perry applied a tool called Ocean Modifier to animate Turner's aqueous brushstrokes into a template of the ocean. The

projection, as one stands before it, flicks between waves rendered in the yellow ochres and grays of Turner's original palette, and a slick purple, signifying the presence of the artist's hand as author and editor of this work. The color purple within the Blender program is a glitch and, in turn, an encrypted signifier, an indicator to the user that, in the artist's words, "there is a missing texture or material . . . a warning to a maker . . . [that] something is missing."⁶

Thus, the piece exists as a corrective historical error, a uniquely feminist coding of Black narrative and the bodies therein, gesturing toward the edges of stories both hidden and untold, the intergenerational trauma that was seeded in the massacre's wake. Reflecting on this piece, Perry notes, "I'm interested in thinking about how blackness shifts, morphs, and embodies technology to combat oppression and surveillance throughout the diaspora. Blackness is agile."⁷

This "shift[ing], morph[ing], and embody[ing]" of technology as a means of pushing back against an exploitative hypervisibility is essential. The readability of glitched bodies in their choreography and topography, as they travel the terrain of the online-to-AFK loop is volatile. Responsive to world conditions, we remain intentionally erratic, always morphing and thus always unmapped. The information hidden by encryption

becomes key, edges peeled back solely for those meant to see, process, understand.

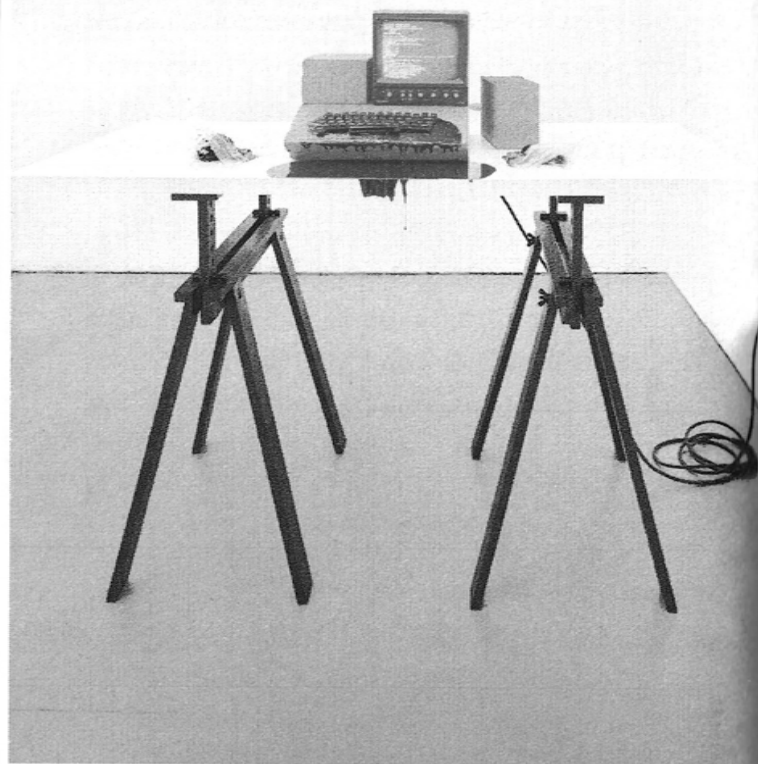
Elsewhere, we remain unreadable. To glitch the body requires the simultaneous occupation of *some-where* and *no-where*, *no-thing* and *every-thing*. We consent not to be a single being frozen in binary code, and, as such, consent as well not to be a single site. This embrace of multiplicity is strategic; as glitched bodies travel outward through every space, we affirm and celebrate the infinite failure of arrival at any place. Far beyond fixity, we find ourselves in outer space, exploring the breadth of cosmic corporeality.

We cannot allow these territories of *some-where*, *no-where*, *no-thing*, and *every-thing* to be delineated by the mainstream. Supremacy will not relinquish its space, those imagined sites building toward worlds of hyper-objects that, hyper-gendered, aim to erase us. We, the glitch, will encrypt. Only as refusal will our data continue to perform, transform, transmute, transmogrify, travel.

07 – GLITCH IS ANTI-BODY

The safe passage of bodies AFK continues to be determined by race, class, and the legibility of one's gender. This volatility of the offline landscape where physical harm—and the systematic ending of life—is regularly enacted on bodies that do not “fit” makes it important to consider how to create safer spaces both on- and offline, working against the present necropolitical narrative. While online spaces remain imperfect, often holding a somber mirror up to the world around us, online communities can create space to talk back to toxic, binary tropes of masculinity/femininity. Embracing the plausibility of range—that is, fantasizing, playing, experimenting by donning different “skins”—becomes an act of empowerment, self-discovery, and even self-care. The skin of cyberidentity is uniquely queer, what theorist Paul B. Preciado even goes so far as to celebrate as a “form . . . of transvestism.”⁷ The digital, in giving us the capacity to perform different selves—quite literally putting them on, then taking them off, as we grow with or away from them—shows us that, as Preciado puts it, “Gender is not simply and purely performative [but rather that] . . . gender is first and foremost prosthetic.”⁸

09 – GLITCH IS VIRUS



gender is a magic trick i forgot how to
perform

—Billy-Ray Belcourt, “The Cree Word for a Body Like
Mine is Weesageechak”

What can we learn from a computer virus? A computer virus corrupts data. A computer virus costs capitalism. It degrades productivity within the machine. A computer virus is a threat to the function of the machine and its economy. A machine transforms into one that cannot perform, that quite literally *cannot work*, *forgets how to work*, *works against its function*. It challenges the endemic correlation between value and labor, dangerous in its uselessness.

Machines are expected to work well and work quickly. A computer virus triggers the machinic responses of slowness in ways that are unpredictable to the user: endless buffering, crashing, damaging, deleting, reformatting. This slowness shifts time and space, altering a person's relationship to the machine. In our daily life when confronted with a computer that shuts down unexpectedly or takes ages to reboot as a result of machinic

failure, our reaction is to get up and move. We change course when confronted with systems that refuse to perform.

A virus breaks, and so we are delivered into the time and space of brokenness. Inevitably, the presence of a virus shakes us into an awareness of our bodies and being. The presence of a virus prompts an awakening. This comes through the recognition that the loop between online and AFK is not seamless. Rather, through its fissures and faults, the virus makes brokenness a space, placing us within the break itself. As glitch feminists, when we embody the virus as a vehicle of resistance, we are putting a wrench into the machinic gears of gender, striking against its economy, immersing ourselves inside of brokenness, inside of the break.

We want to infect, to corrupt ordinary data. To quote theorist and philosopher Jack Halberstam, known for his concept of "the queer art of failure": "What we want after 'the break' will be different from what we think we want before the break and both are necessarily different from the desire that issues from being in the break."¹ What glitch feminism proposes here then is this: perhaps we want the break, we want to fail. We strive for oozing, challenging bodies full of seams. We want wild, amorous, monstrous bodies. Through our presence as a glitch, we want to stand before, within, and

outside of brokenness. The break an error, the error a passageway.

Once we have infected, we want to travel outward in every direction. We want to touch everything, caress *every-fucking-body*, twist the machine. Viral, we want to multiply. We want to cramp culture, make society sweat. We want to cause seizure, a rush of fluids, create sticky, runny spaces where everything can come into contact and blur. That blur is a beginning again, a journey. That journey is a genesis.

In Stefano Harney and Fred Moten's 2013 text *The Undercommons*, Moten argues: "The only thing we can do is tear this shit down completely and build something new."² Glitch feminism asks: *Can a break be a form of building something new? Can our breaking shit be a correction, too?*

The artist American Artist calls out to this notion of brokenness in their 2017 essay "Black Gooley Universe."³ The essay revisits the origin story of graphical user interfaces (or GUIs, pronounced "gooseys") as a site to be problematized, one that establishes a binary of white digital interfaces as the indicator of modern transparency with black interfaces posited as outdated and opaque. These are signifiers of design choices and the history of white, cisgender drivers behind them. Artist peels back this logic, positing the "black gooley" as a useful erratum with revolutionary potential:

Blackness has, so to say, formed the ground for white, with black gooey being antithetical to the values of the white screen. Black gooey might then be a platform of slowness ("dragged time," "colored time"), refusal, thought, complexity, critique, softness, loudness, transparency, uselessness, and brokenness. A planar body that longs for the solitude and vastness of the command-line, yet nuanced and sharp, to usurp and destroy a contemporary hegemonic interface.⁴

The artist changed their name to American Artist in the early years of their career, an avatar intended to allow Artist to move through online space with a degree of anonymity. Simultaneously, Artist's name change pushes back at the quiet yet ever-aggressive bias of search engine optimization (SEO), Google's "roving eye" that by surfacing and prioritizing only certain results, establishes a hierarchized social narrative, history, and visual culture. Now anyone searching "American artist" on the Internet, receives American Artist as the first hit, right alongside, for example, Google's suggested selection of qualified "Artists / United States" such as Andy Warhol, Jean-Michel Basquiat, Edward Hopper, Jackson Pollock, and Jasper Johns. In this way, Artist gently subverts and challenges a canon, with the presence of their name in the company of a mastery recognized by art history, standing

as a durational performance that is virally, algorithmically enacted through their avatar, without the artist's physical self ever even being present.

The work of the avatar positions Artist's engagement of what they name as "Black radicalism and organized labor [in] a context of networked virtual life"⁵ at a unique intersection, a crossroads encountered by those looking for Artist, and, too, by those who are not but may stumble across Artist's work accidentally in searching. With the search term "American artist" having innumerable results following the first hit of Artist's own website, the artist's legal name has no trace, rendering Artist in a sort of spatial limbo, a viral every-where and no-where that, in breaking with the standards of hypervisibility of pop blackness on the Internet. This action stands in the break and shows us how we might ourselves break broken systems via the creative re-application of these systems' own material toward the purpose of a strategic disruption and refusal.

Yes! Why not break the thing that's broken? Why not corrupt the corrupted? The foundation we build on is faulty. Course correcting, we will rise in our errata. We resist being subsumed; we keep sight of the beyond, those rapturous wormholes where rupture can get rolling. The beyond is blurred, it is runny. Our blur is a dance floor at 4AM, that moment where in the crush of all-bodies lit up

under strobes like firecrackers, we become no-body, and in the gorgeous crush of no-body, *we become every-body*. Our song is playing, now let us build a gooey world to go along with it.

The glitch is a tool: it is socio-cultural malware. Bodies traveling through the glitch fail joyfully, as currents along wires that vein social machinery, prompting freeze, flounder, a shuddering shutdown. The glitch is disinformation, virally transmitted as a means of undermining the architecture of gender, shaking it at its core, revealing its inherent fallacy.

Gender is a carefully constructed economic performance as much as it is a socio-cultural one. Gender exists and is protected as a means of insuring bodies, bestowing value on those who labor under its coercion successfully and compliantly, ascribing to its aggressive algorithm. Encrypted anti-bodies, body errors, systemically unreadable, push the machine of gender to its limits. Now wobbly and weakened by this virus, the machine is readied for movement, for change.

We, the viral glitch, want broken ruins, a pollution as politic: punctures in the surface, a bubbling skin, all hell to break loose, destroying all that shit. The alternative is *this* world right now, *this* life—and this world is not enough. We cannot wait around to be remembered, to be humanized, to be seen. It is our responsibility collectively

to infect, and, as we prompt social seizure, to bear witness to and for one another, to make impossible pathways secure and viable as all else short-circuits toward a triggered collapse.

ALL BODIES CAN BE EVERY-BODY. We can get free! Writer Saidiya Hartman notes that “captivity . . . engenders the necessity of redress, the inevitability of its failure, and the constancy of repetition yielded by this failure.”⁶ As we fail, we morph. As we morph, we transcend captivity, slippery to those forces that strive to restrict, restrain, and censor us. Glitch-as-virus presents us with a sharp vision of decay, a nonperformance that veers us toward a wild unknown. This is where we bloom.

It's time for new mechanics.

Let's mutate, please.

Bye, binary! Buffer forever.